

though it's best if you can avoid spending any money. No lawyers, no ultimatums, no threats. Just wait. It's only three months.

Of course, it can be hard to think rationally during the 90-Day Cool-Down, to protect the family dynasty you've built. After three months have passed, reconvene and see where you both stand. If there's a way to salvage your marriage, do it. If not, I maintain that you are both in a far more relaxed place to open a dialogue now than you were three months ago, and you are less likely to make rash and costly mistakes.

Money Mistake: *Your Relationship Is Dead*

The Fix: *Get a Shadow Divorce Instead of a Paper One*

If you decide the best thing to do is end the partnership, that's okay. But that doesn't mean you absolutely have to dissolve the dynasty. Most people assume their ex wants to "screw" them by hiding assets during the divorce process. Each side lawyers up, arming themselves for battle, and the Great Cash Waste begins. You might as well give \$100 bills to everyone around the conference table, pass around a Zippo and tell them to light them on fire. Divorce lawyers are just programmed to take advantage of your emotional distress.

There's another option, especially for those over 60. If you both admit the partnership is over, map out a plan to monetize and split your assets without going through a costly paper divorce. That's a "shadow divorce." It's simple: if you own a home, sell it. If there's a mortgage, pay off the remaining debt and simply divide the cash 50/50. Each party should set up their own account in their own name. Furniture or other non-liquid assets can be divided between the parties or sold.

The one caveat here is that if you sell your house, you'll have to pay taxes on capital gains. This can be financially devastating, especially if your home has been in the family a long time, because approximately a third of the value will be going to the government.

If you own other real estate besides the family home, consider not selling it; this way, you avoid bleeding out your assets in capital